came to India in the seventh century. The principal part of the ‘mutilated inscription’ on the pillar, in his words, stated that ‘Asoka-raja with a firm principle of faith has thrice bestowed Jambudvipa as a religious offering on Buddha, the Dharma and the assembly, and thrice he has redeemed it with his jewels and treasure; and this is the record thereof.’[31] Xuanzang had a remarkable appetite for antiquarian detail, noting such facts about many other places to which he travelled or where he halted.

He encountered Ashokan stone pillars at many places, including Sravasti, Varanasi, Niglihawa (described as the place of the Krakuchhanda Buddha), and Lumbini. Occasionally, the existing state of the pillar is also described. The Lumbini pillar was broken in the middle. This was because it fell to the ground, we are told, ‘by the contrivance of a wicked dragon’.[32] The glittering veneer of an Ashokan column near Varanasi is admired, ‘bright and shining as a mirror; its surface is glistening and smooth as ice.’[33]

While the memory of Ashoka having set up stone pillars persisted, what his epigraphs recorded was entirely forgotten. The pillar at Niglihawa, while recognized as Ashokan, is said to have been engraved with ‘a record connected with the nirvana’ of an earlier Buddha.[34] Later, even the connection of such pillars with Ashoka was forgotten. One sees, from an absence in chronicles about the fourteenth-century ruler Firuz Shah Tughlaq, that when he brought the Topra and Meerut pillars of Ashoka to Delhi their creator king’s name does not feature, suggesting it was not known. The Buddhist connections of some of the pillars may have survived all the same. In Nepal, as we saw, Ripumalla, also a fourteenth-century ruler, inscribed his name and the message ‘Om Mani Padme Hum’—the mantra common among Tibetan Buddhists—on the Ashokan pillars at Lumbini and Nigali Sagar. This suggests that these locations continued to be important places of pilgrimage, even among royalty. Ripumalla’s decision to inscribe his message on Ashoka’s pillars may well mean that he